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LONDON, ONTARIO · SPECIAL COMMUNITY FEATURE

The Oliva Family

Giuseppe and Carmela Oliva

Children: Philip, Domenic, Josephine, John, Frank, Tony, Steve, Ross, Nicolina

From Italy to London: The Oliva Family's Journey of Faith, Family & Fine Hair

How one immigrant family built London Ontario's first Italian-owned salon empire — and left a legacy of 150 family members still gathering every year

By Alex Weber · The London Free Press



Frank, Ross and Tony Oliva — 55 years behind the chair at Roma's Beauty Salons.

ARRIVING IN CANADA

Arriving in Canada in 1951, eldest brother Philip began the family's immigration to Canada. Slowly, every few years, another family member joined him making the trek from being grocers and bakers in Italy to their new home and a better life in Canada.

A FATHER FIGURE

Philip became a father-figure to the family as the Oliva family's biological father passed away in 1944, leaving their mother, Carmela, a widow with eight children and pregnant with the youngest, Nicolina. Brother Domenic arrived approximately eight months later.

BUILDING A NEW LIFE

Upon his arrival in Canada, Philip earned a living by farming, then shovelling clay on a construction job, learning the English language from his co-workers. Two years after Philip's arrival, brother Frank and sister Josephine came to Canada settling in Toronto where Frank worked several jobs while learning to speak and write English.

LEARNING THE TRADE

Prior to coming to Canada, Frank had enrolled in hairdressing school in Italy while brother Tony arrived and began school in the morning, becoming a barber after classes.

LONDON CALLS

The brothers pooled their savings to bring their mother to Canada from Italy. The boys bought Mrs. Oliva a house in Toronto. Having difficulty finding work in Toronto, Philip suggested moving to London as a city to begin their business. Leaving brother Dominic in Toronto, the remainder of the family moved to London to open their first hair salon — in fact, London Ontario's first salon owned by Italians.

ROMA'S BEAUTY SALONS

Brother Ross began hairdressing school at night classes. Approximately 18 months later, he began working as a hairdresser in the family's second hair salon.

THE FAMILY REUNITES

In 1964, brothers John and Steve both arrived in Canada; John settling in London while Steve moved to Toronto. Brother Philip then pursued his hairdressing licence as did brother-in-law John Oliva, married to Josephine and, coincidentally, sharing the same last name. The family opened seven salons in total — locations of Roma's Beauty Salons in many areas of London.

COMPETING AT THE TOP

Oliva success continued as Frank, brother-in-law John and Ross competed in provincial and national Hairdressing competitions. Ross placed second in the Canadian championships and first in the Ontario Competition. Ross married Maria, also a hair dresser and U.S. competition winner.

"London Ontario's first hair salon owned by Italians — and the start of a seven-salon family empire."

55 YEARS & RETIREMENT

In 2012, after 55 years of cutting hair together, the remaining brothers Frank, Tony and Ross decided to retire. They've styled everything from beehives and bouffants to feathered flips and pixie cuts — and their small shop is filled with photos of hairstyles from the past century and trophies from the '60s and '70s when they used to compete in styling competitions.

A FAMILY LEGACY

Predeceased by her son Philip, the family matriarch passed away in 2000, leaving the remaining family members to carry on traditions of annual family reunions to share the memories of a growing family as well as traditional Italian foods, dances, laughs and stories.

150 STRONG

The annual reunions invite 150 family members, including grandchildren and great-grandchildren from the original Carmela and Giuseppe Oliva. Eager to spend more time with grandchildren and focus on other hobbies, they close the salon for good this weekend.

ROMA'S BY THE NUMBERS

1951 Philip arrives in Canada

7 Salons opened across London

55 Years cutting hair together

2nd Canadian Championship — Ross Oliva

1st Ontario Competition — Ross Oliva

150 Family members at annual reunion

Roma's Beauty Salons · London, Ontario · Est.
1950s · A Family Tradition